

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN THE REPUBLIC OF CONGO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the forests, peatlands, and rivers of the Republic of Congo — but here the stakes are global, because beneath the swamp forests of the north lies the Cuvette Centrale, the largest tropical peatland on earth because beneath the vast swamp forests of the north lies the Cuvette Centrale, the single largest tropical peatland found anywhere on earth, and what happens to it matters not only to the Congolese who live there and what happens to it matters greatly not only to the Congolese who live there but to the whole planet's climate. but to the stability of the whole planet's climate. The Cuvette Centrale, shared with the neighbouring Democratic Republic of Congo, holds on the order of thirty billion tonnes of carbon — as much as the world emits from fossil fuels in some three years — locked in waterlogged peat beneath one of the great rainforests. The Cuvette Centrale, shared with the neighbouring Democratic Republic of Congo, holds on the order of thirty billion tonnes of carbon — as much as the entire world emits from fossil fuels in roughly three years — locked away in waterlogged peat beneath one of the great tropical rainforests of the earth. locked safely away in waterlogged peat beneath one of the very great tropical rainforests of the earth. It shelters gorillas, forest elephants, and rare life, and sustains the fishing and forest communities who have always lived there. It shelters lowland gorillas, forest elephants, and a wealth of rare life, and it sustains the fishing and forest communities who have always lived along its rivers and in its swamp forests. And it is threatened: the government has held and awarded oil blocks that overlap the peatlands, on an environmental assessment so old it predated the peatlands' own scientific discovery, and logging presses at the forest's edge. the government has held and awarded oil exploration blocks that overlap the peatlands, on the basis of an environmental assessment so old that it predated the peatlands' own scientific discovery, and industrial logging presses steadily at the forest's edge. This guide will be honest that the Republic of Congo is a poor, oil-dependent nation that genuinely needs revenue. This guide will be honest that the Republic of Congo is a genuinely poor, oil-dependent nation that badly needs revenue, that its government makes a fair argument that it has the same right to develop its resources that industrialised nations used, that the political space to oppose is constrained, and that no threat here has been finally beaten; but it will show that the levers here — the peatlands' global climate value, the state's own commitments to protect them, the climate finance that could pay to keep the carbon in the ground, the weak economics of peatland oil, and the pressure on the oil companies and their financiers — are real, and that the honest path is not to deny a poor nation its development but to fund a better one. and that the honest path here is not to deny a poor nation its development at all but rather to fund a better one.

The Congolese story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever pressed together. The second is distinctly Congolese, and it is what gives this guide its particular force. **Because the peatlands are of global climate value, because the state itself has signed commitments to protect them and seeks to be seen as a steward of the Congo Basin, because the world could pay to keep the carbon in the ground rather than have it drilled, and because the oil beneath is of doubtful worth, the levers run through the global stakes and the state's**

own commitments: the climate value, the state's promises, the climate finance, and the pressure on the oil companies. That combination — the global climate value, the state's own commitments, the climate finance, and the pressure on the oil interests — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because for a peatland that matters to the whole planet, the whole planet has reason, and means, to help keep it whole.

But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **The nation is poor and oil-dependent, its development argument is fair, the space is constrained, and no threat is beaten.** The Republic of Congo depends on oil for most of its revenue and is heavily indebted, so the pull toward drilling is real and understandable; its government argues, with genuine force, that a poor nation has the same right to profit from its resources that the rich nations used to build their wealth, and that if the world wants the carbon kept in the ground it should pay for it — an argument this guide takes seriously rather than dismissing; the political space for open opposition is limited; and the oil blocks are held and the pressures real, with no final victory won. This guide does not pretend the nation's development needs are not genuine, or that the sovereignty argument is not fair, or that opposition is free. What it shows is how, through the global climate value, the state's own commitments, the climate finance, and the pressure on the oil interests, communities and their allies can press to keep the peatlands whole — honestly, by funding a better path rather than denying a poor nation its future.

Most people who care about the peatlands do not know HOW to use the levers a globally vital ecosystem in a poor, oil-dependent state offers. They see the oil blocks drawn across the swamp forest, the logging at the edge, the carbon bomb ticking — and either accept it as the price of a poor nation's development, or demand simply that the drilling stop, which ignores the fair development need, and rarely grasp the levers that work: the global climate value, the state's own commitments, the climate finance that could pay to keep the carbon stored, the doubtful economics of the oil. The gap between the peatland kept and the peatland drilled is here often a gap of method — the method of using the global climate value, the state's own commitments, the climate finance, and the pressure on the oil interests together.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Congolese reality as it is, which is a poor, oil-dependent, constrained state holding a peatland the whole planet needs. It is written for the person — in a forest community, in the country's small environmental and civil-society world, or among its international partners — who sees the peatlands threatened and wants to know what can be done in a poor nation whose development need is real. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the global climate value, the state's own commitments, the climate finance, and the pressure on the oil interests — with the honest qualifiers that the nation is poor and oil-dependent, its development argument is fair, the space is constrained, and no threat is beaten, so the work is to fund and press a better path, not to deny a poor nation its future.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, adapted to a globally vital peatland in a poor, constrained state:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the project, the harm, and the global stake)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build the evidence -- the carbon and the flaws)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(build the community and the global coalition)
STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & CLIMATE-GOVERNANCE	(commitments, finance, assessment)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY	(make it a global-climate cause)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of the carbon and the flawed assessment feeds the state's commitments, the climate finance, and the oil-interest pressure at once; the community and the global coalition organise together; a climate-finance offer, a commitment invoked, or a financier pressed is both pressure and a spur to the next. The effort that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still difficult — chance of keeping the peatlands whole.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. The Republic of Congo's — a globally vital peatland in a poor, oil-dependent state — give a distinctive set:

- **The global climate value.** The peatlands' **thirty billion tonnes of carbon** make them a global concern, bringing the world's climate movement, finance, and diplomacy to bear.
- **The state's own commitments.** The state's **signed pledges to protect the peatlands** and its wish to be seen as a Congo Basin steward can be held to.
- **The climate finance.** The **finance to pay for keeping the carbon in the ground** can meet the fair development need without drilling.
- **The weak economics and flawed assessment.** The **doubtful oil reserves and the outdated assessment** make peatland oil a bad and legally weak bet.
- **The pressure on the oil interests.** The **oil companies and their financiers** can be pressed to stay out of the peatlands.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers prevail, or that the nation's needs are not real. The nation is **poor and oil-dependent**; its development argument is **fair**; the space is **constrained**; and no threat is **beaten**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it seeks to fund a better path rather than deny development — and shows how to use the real tools this situation offers — the global climate value, the state's own commitments, the climate finance, and the pressure on the oil interests — to keep the peatlands whole, honestly acknowledging the poverty, the fair sovereignty argument, the constrained space, and the fact that the threat is not beaten.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must see that the levers run through the global stakes and the state's own commitments, because a poor nation will not simply forgo revenue, but it can be offered a better path and held to its word. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides a project's fate, at which level, and where the leverage is real. And map where the global climate value, the state's own commitments, the climate finance, and the pressure on the oil interests apply, because in the Republic of Congo a peatland-destroying project is met not by open confrontation, which is constrained, nor by mere refusal, which ignores the fair development need, but by making the peatland worth more kept whole — through its global value, the state's commitments, and the finance to keep the carbon stored.

The Levels of Decision

A Congolese project runs through levels that reach from the forest to the world.

The state and its ministries. The **state, the oil and forest ministries, and the environment ministry** grant the blocks and drive the projects, and are the authority to be persuaded — with a better-funded path

and their own commitments — rather than confronted.

The state's own commitments and diplomacy. The **peatland pledges and the Congo Basin diplomacy** are the state's own standards, and a real channel, since holding the state to its own word is a genuine path.

The oil companies and their financiers. The **oil companies holding the blocks and the banks and investors behind them** can be pressed to stay out of the peatlands.

The climate-finance and international bodies. The **climate-finance funds, the forest and climate partners, and the international bodies** can pay to keep the carbon in the ground and press for protection.

The communities and civil society. The **forest and Indigenous communities and the small civil society** who depend on the peatlands can act, within the constraints, on their rights and their knowledge.

The Journey of a Project

A Congolese project — an oil block in the peatland, a logging concession, a road into the swamp forest — moves from a state plan driven by revenue need, through the licensing and the assessment, toward the drilled peatland or the protected carbon, with the **global climate value, the state's commitments, the climate finance, and the oil-interest pressure** able to intervene. **The global climate value and the climate finance are where the project is best met, and the state's commitments and the oil-interest pressure are what carry it** — and using them together is the distinctive Congolese approach. The distinctive levers are the **global climate value, the state's commitments, the climate finance, and the oil-interest pressure**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **what peatland, forest, or community it harms, what carbon it would release and what the state has pledged, and how the climate finance and the oil-interest pressure can be brought to bear**, because those are where a project can genuinely be met.

Follow the Project, the Carbon, and the Finance

Behind a project stand the state, its revenue need, and the carbon at stake. Trace who decides, who profits, what is harmed, and — importantly here — **what carbon the project would release, what the state has pledged to protect, what finance could pay to keep it stored, and which companies and financiers stand behind it**. Two questions unlock most Congolese efforts: **What is harmed, and what global carbon and community depend on it?** and **Which lever — the climate value, the commitments, the finance, the oil-interest pressure — can meet it, while funding the fair development need?** The global climate value, the climate finance, and the state's commitments are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Congolese effort ultimately serves these: the documentation exists to establish the global carbon and the project's flaws; the local-and-global community exists to press the case with local right and global reach; and the media exists to bring the world's climate concern and finance to bear. Keep the global climate value, the climate finance, and the state's commitments at the centre of every submission, proposal, and story, and the effort retains a clear spine that runs from a single swamp-forest community to the world's climate and the world's willingness to pay, grounding the whole struggle in the planetary worth of the peatland and the fair bargain that could keep it whole.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a project, because they are the levers — and they reach from the forest to the world. The **state, the oil and forest ministries, and the environment ministry**; the **state's own commitments and Congo Basin diplomacy**; the **oil companies and their financiers**; the **climate-finance funds and international partners**; and the **forest and Indigenous communities and**

civil society. In the Republic of Congo, the **global climate value, the state's commitments, the climate finance, and the oil-interest pressure** are the most distinctive levers, and they span the nation and the world. Each is a separate front, and a project shown to threaten a globally vital peatland, against the state's own pledges, when finance could pay to keep the carbon stored, can genuinely be pressed — through the climate value, the finance, and the oil-interest pressure — though, honestly, the nation is poor and oil-dependent, its development argument is fair, the space is constrained, and no threat is beaten, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep seeking to fund a better path.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging that the nation is poor and oil-dependent, that its development argument is fair, and that the space is constrained, even as the global climate value, the state's commitments, and the climate finance give real leverage. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how peatland-and-oil conflicts tend to go in the Congo Basin and comparable settings, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the **global carbon and the flawed assessment** can be documented, whether the **state's commitments and the climate finance** can be brought to bear, and whether the **oil companies and financiers** can be pressed. Where the global value is shown and the finance is offered, the levers here are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the nation needs revenue, the sovereignty argument is fair, and no threat is beaten.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	15–25%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Global-climate-value case	40–60%	months–years	low	The world's concern engaged
State's-commitments channel	35–55%	months–years	low	The peatland pledges invoked
Climate-finance / keep-it-in-ground	35–55%	years	high	The carbon paid to stay stored
Flawed-assessment / economics	40–60%	months–years	low	The oil shown a bad, weak bet
Oil-company / financier pressure	35–55%	months–years	low	The companies pressed to stay out
Community / land rights	30–50%	months–years	low	The forest communities' rights upheld
All levers together	35–55%	years	high	Peatlands kept whole; better path funded

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and the Republic of Congo's real strengths are the global stakes and the state's own word: the **global climate value**, the **state's commitments**, the **climate finance**, and the **oil-interest pressure**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the nation is **poor and oil-dependent**, its development argument is **fair**, the space is **constrained**, and no threat is **beaten** — so progress comes through the global value, the commitments, the finance, and the oil-interest pressure, funding a better path, not through mere refusal or open confrontation.

*A note on cost and risk: some levers here — the global-value case, the flawed-assessment argument, the financier pressure — cost mainly organisation, science, and international connection. The climate finance is the costly lever, but it is the one that meets the fair development need, and it is the world's to supply. The scarce resources are **the scientific and legal capacity, the international and finance connections, and the careful navigation of a constrained state** — much of it reachable through the global climate movement and the forest-and-climate funds. And because the nation is poor and its need real, the argument that pays for a better path, rather than merely refusing, is the most persuasive and the most just.*

Effectiveness Visualization

GLOBAL VALUE + STATE'S COMMITMENTS + FINANCE + OIL-INTEREST PRESSURE:

Global-climate-value case: 40-60%

Global-estimate value case: ██████████ 40-60%
Flawed-assessment / economics: ████████ 40-60%

State's-commitments channel: ■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%

Climate-finance / keep-in-ground:■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%

Oil-company / financier press: ■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%

POOR / OIL-DEPENDENT / FAIR DEVELOPMENT NEED -- harder ground:

Mere refusal, no finance: ■■ ignores the fair need

Funding a better path: the real path

Peatland kept / carbon stored:■■■■■■■■■■■ achievable in part

The harm & carbon documented: ■■■■■■ the reliable foundation

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in the Republic of Congo are **the global climate value, the state's commitments, the climate finance, and the oil-interest pressure** — used together, and funding a better path. The global-value and finance levers show the ceiling: a peatland the whole world needs, with the world paying to keep it stored, can genuinely be kept whole. The poverty and the fair development need show the honest floor: a poor nation will not, and should not have to, simply forgo revenue. Most Congolese efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real — able to engage the world's climate concern, invoke the state's pledges, offer finance, and press the oil interests — but that mere refusal ignores a fair need, and the surest result is that the global carbon is documented and a better, financed path advanced.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The global climate value and the climate finance** — the peatlands' worth to the world, and the means to pay for keeping it.
2. **The state's own commitments** — the peatland pledges the state can be held to.
3. **The flawed assessment and weak economics** — the oil shown a bad and legally weak bet.
4. **The oil-company and financier pressure** — the companies and banks pressed to stay out.
5. **The documented carbon and community** — the evidence, and the forest people's rights, that ground it all.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **The carbon makes it global** — thirty billion tonnes is the world's concern, and the world's lever. **The state made pledges** — a Congo Basin steward that signed peatland commitments can be held to them. **Finance can meet the need** — paying to keep the carbon stored answers the fair development argument. **The oil is a weak bet** — doubtful reserves and an outdated assessment undercut the project. **But the need is real and the space constrained** — so the path is a funded better one, carefully pressed. The through-line: **document the carbon and the flawed assessment; engage the world's climate concern; invoke the state's own pledges; offer the finance to keep the carbon stored;**

press the oil companies and financiers; and fund a better path — because an effort that does can genuinely keep the peatlands whole, while being honest that the nation is poor, its development argument fair, and no threat yet beaten.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact project and harm — and the leverage, which here runs through the global stakes and the finance. Vague concern goes nowhere, and mere refusal ignores the fair need; an effort aimed at "this oil block or concession in this peatland, releasing this global carbon and harming this community, against the state's own pledges, on a flawed assessment, when finance could pay to keep it stored, and these companies and financiers stand behind it" is a real, workable effort. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

- 1. What is harmed?** This is the first question here. What **peatland, forest, or community** does the project threaten — the carbon-rich swamp forest, the wildlife, the fishing and forest people.
- 2. What global carbon and value are at stake?** How much **carbon the project would release**, and the global climate value of the peatland it threatens.
- 3. What has the state pledged, and how flawed is the assessment?** What the **state's own peatland commitments** require, and how the **assessment and the oil's economics** fall short.
- 4. What finance could keep it stored?** What **climate finance and payments** could keep the carbon in the ground and meet the fair development need.
- 5. Which companies and financiers stand behind it, and how to work safely?** Which **oil companies and their financiers** can be pressed, and how the effort proceeds through international and within-system channels, carefully.

A Worked Example

Suppose an oil block overlapping the peatlands threatens to release a vast store of global carbon and harm the forest communities, on an assessment that predates the peatlands' discovery, held by an oil company with international financiers.

Working the five questions: **what is harmed? What carbon and value? What has the state pledged, and how flawed the assessment? What finance could keep it stored?** And which companies and financiers, and how to work safely? The driver is the state's revenue need and the oil interest, with the global value, the commitments, the finance, and the oil-interest pressure as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the state needs revenue and will drill" to a real effort: document the carbon and the flawed assessment; engage the world's climate concern; invoke the state's own pledges; offer the finance to keep the carbon stored and meet the development need; and press the oil company and its financiers — all funding a better path, not merely refusing. That is a workable effort suited to the Republic of Congo — one that makes the peatland worth more kept whole. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a fight over a global treasure in a poor, constrained state: they turn what might seem an impossible target — a poor nation determined to develop its resources, in a state that limits dissent — into a set of specific, answerable questions, each attached to a lever that works with the global stakes and the fair need rather than against a poor nation's future. The harm becomes a documentable release of global

carbon. The stake becomes the world's climate, and the world's concern. The state's word becomes a pledge that can be invoked. The need becomes something a financed alternative can meet. And the companies become interests that can be pressed. That translation — from a seemingly immovable determination to develop into a set of specific actions that keep a global treasure whole while funding a poor nation's future — is the first and most important thing a Congolese effort does, because it moves the fight from a doomed demand for sacrifice onto the ground of global value and fair bargain, where a poor nation and the whole world can both gain.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, distinctively, the decisive evidence is the global carbon the peatland holds and the flaws in the project. A ministry, a financier, a climate fund, and the world all move on evidence — and in the Republic of Congo, a clear record of the carbon, the harm, the flawed assessment, and the fair alternative is precisely what an effort turns into a real result, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Carbon, and the Pledges

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project, its driver, and the harm** — the oil block and the peatland it overlaps, the concession and the forest it opens — and, decisively here, **the global carbon it would release and what the state has pledged**. The science of the peatland's carbon, mapped by international researchers, is authoritative, and the state's commitments are on the record. Establish exactly **what the project is, what carbon it threatens, and what the state pledged**, because the global-carbon-against-the-state's-own-pledge is the case's foundation.

Layer 2: The Harm, the Carbon, and the Community

Document the harm with the science. Establish the **ecological and climate harm** — the carbon that would be released, the peatland and forest damaged, the wildlife and the fishing and forest communities harmed — drawing on **the international peatland science, the carbon estimates, and the community's knowledge**. And establish the **global value** — the peatland as one of earth's great carbon stores and a home to rare life and to people. The carbon science and the community's testimony make the harm both a global climate danger and a local injustice.

Layer 3: The Harm, the Flaws, the Finance, and the Path

Finally, document the case and the alternative. Does the **science** prove a vast carbon release? How does it **breach the state's pledges**? How **flawed is the assessment and how weak the economics**? What **finance** could keep the carbon stored and meet the development need? And which **companies and financiers** stand behind it? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case that shows the peatland worth more kept whole, and a better path to fund it. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented global carbon, a broken pledge, a flawed assessment, a weak economics, and a financed alternative are exactly what let a Congolese effort keep the peatland whole. Build it well, and the global climate value, the state's commitments, the climate finance, and the oil-interest pressure become the effort's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: the decisive and distinctive feature of a Congolese peatland case is that the science of the carbon is both authoritative and recent, and that it can be paired with the equally documented flaws of the project to produce a case that is unusually hard to answer. The carbon estimate — one of the world's largest tropical peatland stores, holding carbon on the

scale of years of global emissions — rests on international scientific mapping that no proponent can credibly dismiss, and it establishes at a stroke that this is a matter of global, not merely local, importance. Set beside it, the project's flaws are stark: an environmental assessment that predated the very discovery of the peatlands and so could not have assessed the risk of drilling them, and reserves whose worth is doubtful. Building this layer well means marrying the two — the undeniable global carbon and the demonstrable project flaws — so that the case says, at once, that the stakes are planetary and the project is weak, which is precisely the combination most likely to move financiers, funders, and the world, and to give even a constrained government reason to reconsider.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists — and here the decisive evidence is the global carbon and the project's flaws. Here is where the material tends to live in a Congolese effort, and how to get it — with the **carbon**, the **pledges**, the **flaws and finance**, and the **oil interests** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Carbon and Pledges Record

Start with the carbon and the state's word, which are the foundation. **The international peatland science, the carbon estimates, and the state's commitments** establish the global stake and the standard; the distinctive strengths here are the **authoritative carbon science** and the **state's own peatland pledges**, both public and reachable. Establish the **carbon at stake and what the state pledged to protect**, because the global-carbon-against-the-pledge is the case's spine. Establish exactly **how much carbon is threatened and what the state promised**, because a state that pledged to protect the peatland is exposed when it opens it.

The Harm, Assessment, and Economics Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **harm evidence** — the carbon that would be released, the peatland and forest damaged, the communities harmed — and the **flaw evidence** — the assessment that predated the peatland's discovery and ignored the risk, and the doubtful economics of the reserves — drawing on **the peatland science, the assessment records, and the economic analyses**. This harm-and-flaw evidence turns the case into both a global climate danger and a demonstrably bad and legally weak project.

The Finance and Alternative Record

Document the better path, which answers the fair need. Gather the record of **the climate finance and payments** — the forest and climate funds, the results-based payments, the carbon and conservation finance — that could pay to keep the carbon stored and meet the nation's revenue need; and the **fair development alternative** it offers. A community and coalition that can show a real financed alternative — the world paying to keep the carbon in the ground, meeting the development need without the drilling — holds the lever that makes opposition just rather than mere refusal.

The Oil-Interest, International, and Community Record

Document the pressure points and the people. Gather the record of the **oil companies and their financiers** who stand behind the blocks and can be pressed; the **international climate and forest bodies** who can help; and the **forest and Indigenous communities** whose rights and knowledge are at stake. A coalition joined to the international movement, able to press the companies and financiers, and rooted in the forest communities holds levers that span the world and the swamp forest.

The People, the System, and the Care

Finally, map the human terrain and the careful path. Who is affected — the **fishing and forest communities, the Indigenous peoples, and the world's climate** — and who can act: the **communities, the small civil society, the international NGOs, the climate funds**, since the space is constrained. And how does the effort **work through the system and the world with care**, given the constraints? A Congolese effort is advanced largely through the global stakes, the state's commitments, the finance, and the international pressure, within the constraints — so map that coalition deliberately, and let care for those involved, respect for the fair development need, and a realistic sense of the constrained space govern every step.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here this step must be understood in the Congolese way, because open, adversarial organising is constrained, and the "opposition" that works joins the local forest communities with a global coalition, pressing through international, finance, and within-system channels. The task is to build a community — of forest and Indigenous people, small civil society, international NGOs, and climate funders — that presses to keep the peatlands whole, on the global stakes and the state's own commitments, while funding the fair development need.

Why the Local-and-Global Community Is Decisive

In the Republic of Congo, the community that can act joins the local to the global, because a globally vital peatland in a constrained state is defended by the world as much as by its neighbours. That community supplies what an effort runs on: the forest and Indigenous people who live the harm and hold the rights, the small civil society with a voice, the international NGOs and scientists with reach, and — distinctively — the world's climate movement and finance, for which a thirty-billion-tonne carbon store is a global cause. When the local and the global organise together, they become a genuine force. **A community that joins the local forest people to the global climate movement here is not a weaker substitute for open protest; it is the form defence can effectively and safely take in the Republic of Congo — the real foundation of an effort, defending a global treasure by local right and global reach.** This joining of the local and the global is worth dwelling on, because it is the deepest strength of a Congolese effort and the answer to its deepest constraint. A poor forest community, in a state that limits dissent, is weak on its own against a government and an oil industry. But that same community is not alone, because the peatland it defends is not merely its home; it is a carbon store the entire planet has an interest in keeping whole, and that global interest is a source of allies, attention, finance, and pressure that no purely local struggle could command. The task, therefore, is to weld the two together: the local community's rights, knowledge, and moral standing as the people of the forest, and the global movement's science, finance, reach, and pressure as the guardians of the world's climate. Neither alone is enough; the community lacks the leverage, and the global movement lacks the local legitimacy and the on-the-ground reality. Joined, they form something formidable, because they can say together, with one voice, that this is both our home and the world's, and that keeping it whole serves us both.

Finding the Community

Begin with those the harm touches and those who can act — the **forest and Indigenous communities, the small environmental civil society, the international NGOs and scientists, and the climate funders** — and treat the constraints on open dissent honestly, protecting those involved, especially the Indigenous and forest people. Widen to the global climate movement, for whom the peatland is a cause. Name the shared

stake — **our forest, our fish, our carbon, and the world's climate** — because the peatland is at once the community's home and livelihood and the planet's carbon store. Frame the effort around keeping a global treasure whole and funding a better path, not around denying development. There is real power in framing the cause this way, because it transforms the effort from a demand that a poor nation sacrifice into an offer that everyone can gain. A community that says "do not develop" pits itself against the nation's genuine need and the government's fair argument, and casts itself as an obstacle to a poor country's future. A community that says "let us keep this global treasure whole, and let the world pay to make that the nation's better deal" casts itself as the champion of both the forest and the nation, and reframes the whole question from sacrifice to shared gain. This framing is not only safer and more persuasive in a constrained space; it is also truer and more just, because the honest answer to a poor nation's fair claim to develop is not refusal but a better-funded path, and the honest answer to a global climate need is not to demand poor nations bear its cost alone but for the world to pay its share. An effort that names this stake precisely — a global treasure kept whole, a fair bargain for a poor nation, a shared gain — stands on ground that is both strong and right.

Coalition-Building, Local and Global

A community allied is stronger than a community alone, and here it spans the forest and the world. Reach to the **forest and Indigenous communities**; the **small civil society**; the **international NGOs, scientists, and climate funders**; and the **finance and forest partners**. Frame the coalition around the global climate value, the state's commitments, the finance, and the oil-interest pressure. Build breadth from the local to the global, favouring the international and finance channels over open confrontation, and protecting those involved.

Sustaining the Effort

Congolese efforts are sustained through the global stakes, the state's commitments, and the finance. Keep the community **connected, informed, and careful**; mark real steps — a block delayed, a pledge invoked, a financier pressed, a finance offer advanced, a community right upheld. And keep the effort grounded in the global climate value and the state's own word, which are durable and carry global weight. The effort that lasts is the one that joins the local forest people to the world's climate movement, presses the state's own commitments, and funds a better path. Sustaining such an effort is helped, in the Congolese case, by the enduring and growing nature of the global interest on which it rests. Unlike a local protest, which depends on a mobilisation that can be worn down or discouraged, an effort anchored in the peatland's global carbon value rests on an interest that does not fade but grows, as the world's climate crisis deepens and the value of keeping great carbon stores intact rises ever higher on the global agenda. Each year that the science is better understood, each advance in climate finance, each strengthening of the world's resolve to keep carbon in the ground, adds to the foundation of the effort and to the world's willingness to pay for what it protects. The discipline is to keep the effort anchored in that global value and that growing finance, and to keep building the local-and-global coalition patiently, so that the defence of the peatland rests not on the fragile energy of local dissent alone but on the deepening and enduring interest of the whole world in keeping a great carbon store whole.

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & CLIMATE-GOVERNANCE CHALLENGES — THE STATE'S OWN COMMITMENTS, THE CLIMATE FINANCE, AND THE FLAWED ASSESSMENT

This is where a Congolese effort is realistically advanced — not through open confrontation, which is constrained, nor mere refusal, which ignores the fair need, but through the **state's own commitments, the**

climate finance, and the flawed assessment, grounded in the global carbon science. Here the commitment, finance, and assessment levers come together, because in the Republic of Congo a peatland-destroying project, against the state's own pledges, on a flawed assessment, when finance could keep the carbon stored, can be pressed through those levers.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but work around a poor state's genuine need**. The state's commitments are **real but weakly honoured**; the finance is **promising but not yet delivered at scale**; the flawed assessment is **a genuine weakness but not an absolute bar**; and open challenge is **constrained**. What these levers realistically achieve is **the carbon documented, the pledges invoked, the assessment challenged, the finance advanced, and the oil interests pressed** — real outcomes, if not yet the final protection of the peatlands. Enter this front clear-eyed: the state's commitments, the climate finance, and the flawed assessment are the Republic of Congo's distinctive levers, strongest when the **global carbon is shown and a financed alternative is offered** — but the nation is poor, the need real, and the space constrained.

The State's Own Commitments and the Flawed Assessment

The first front is the state's own word and the project's flaws. The Republic of Congo has **signed commitments to protect the peatlands** and seeks to be seen as a steward of the Congo Basin, so holding it to those pledges — invoking the peatland declarations, the Congo Basin diplomacy, and the standing it seeks — is a genuine lever, because a state that hosts peatland-protection summits is exposed when it opens the peatlands to oil. And the **assessment is flawed** — so old it predated the peatlands' scientific discovery and ignored the risk of drilling them — which makes the project legally and procedurally weak; demand a proper, modern assessment, and the doubtful economics of the reserves undercut the case further. Use the state's own commitments and the flawed assessment together, because the state's word and the project's weakness are the case's core. It is worth being clear about both the power and the limits of this commitments-and-assessment front, honestly. Its power is real: a state that has hosted peatland-protection summits, signed international declarations, and sought to lead the Congo Basin has staked reputation and standing on being a steward of these forests, and it is genuinely exposed, before the world and its own partners, when it opens the same peatlands to oil on a discredited assessment. Its limits are equally real: the state made those commitments as a poor nation seeking finance and standing, not as a wealthy one able to forgo revenue, so it can and does argue that its pledges were always conditional on the support that has not fully come, and a flawed assessment can be redone rather than abandoned. Understanding both means using the commitments-and-assessment front for what it does best — exposing the gap between the state's professed stewardship and its conduct, and the procedural weakness of the project — while always pairing it with the climate finance that addresses the honest conditionality of the state's pledges, because a state held to a commitment it made in hope of support it never received will point, not unfairly, to the missing support.

The Climate Finance and the Fair Alternative

The second front is the finance, which answers the fair need. Because the state genuinely needs revenue and fairly argues its right to develop, the effort must offer a **better-funded path**: the **climate finance** — the forest and climate funds, the results-based payments, the carbon and conservation finance — that could pay the nation to keep the carbon in the ground, meeting its need without the drilling. Advance the finance with the international partners, so that keeping the peatland whole becomes the nation's better deal. This front is what makes opposition just and persuasive, because it answers the fair development argument with a real

alternative rather than mere refusal — the world paying for a global good.

The Oil-Interest Pressure and the International Movement

The third front is the companies and the world. The **oil companies holding the blocks and the financiers behind them** can be pressed — through their own climate commitments, their reputational and financial risk, and the global movement — to stay out of the peatlands, as market and financier pressure has moved other frontier projects. And the **international climate and forest movement** brings the world's concern to bear on a global carbon store. Pursued together — the state's commitments, the flawed assessment, the climate finance, the oil-interest pressure, and the international movement — these fronts are how a Congolese effort keeps the peatlands whole, funding a better path, through the global stakes and the state's own word, with care for those involved. It is worth understanding why these fronts reinforce one another so well in the Republic of Congo's particular situation. The state's commitments supply the standard the state set itself and can be held to. The flawed assessment supplies the concrete legal and procedural weakness of the project. The climate finance supplies the answer to the fair development need, without which no opposition is just. The oil-interest pressure supplies a second front against the companies and financiers, independent of the state. And the international movement supplies the global weight, attention, and finance that a purely national effort could never command. Each covers the others' limits: the commitments where a standard is needed, the flawed assessment where a legal handle helps, the finance where the fair need must be met, the oil-interest pressure where the state itself will not move, and the international movement where global weight is required. An effort that grasps this division of labour, and pursues each front together, makes the fullest use of the several levers that a globally vital peatland in a poor state uniquely provides — levers that reach from the swamp forest to the world's banks and climate funds.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same file of carbon and flaws becomes different arguments for the state, the oil companies, the climate funders, and the world. Translate deliberately, and always funding a better path.

For the State and Its Ministries

The state responds to **revenue, development, and its own standing**. Frame the choice as a better deal and its own word: here is a peatland the world will pay you to keep whole, meeting your revenue need without the risk and the broken pledge, and honouring the Congo Basin stewardship you claim. Give them the finance offer and their own commitments, and press for protection funded, not development denied. Make it concrete: *here is a better-paid path, and here is your own pledge*. This is the argument that answers a poor state fairly.

For the Oil Companies and Financiers

The companies and financiers respond to **risk, reputation, and their own climate commitments**. Frame the project as a bad and damaging bet: here is a carbon bomb, a flawed assessment, doubtful reserves, and a reputational and financial risk that breaches your own climate pledges. Give them the flaws and the global stakes, and press them to stay out. A financier mindful of climate risk and reputation, and a company facing a weak and damaging project, can be moved to withdraw.

For the Climate Funders and International Partners

The funders respond to **global carbon and a fundable path**. Frame the peatland as a global prize worth paying to keep: here is thirty billion tonnes of carbon, a poor nation willing to protect it if the need is met, and a chance to fund a globally significant win. Give them the carbon, the finance model, and the state's willingness, and press for the finance to be delivered. A climate funder seeking real, large carbon protection has every reason to pay for this one.

For the World and the Climate Movement

The world responds to **a global carbon bomb and a fair bargain**. Translate the file into a story anyone can grasp: the largest tropical peatland on earth, a carbon store the size of years of global emissions, threatened by oil — and a poor nation ready to protect it if the world helps pay. Frame it as the world's chance to keep a great carbon store whole and to deal fairly with a poor nation. Keep it accurate; the science is strong and overstatement would be caught. And respect the fair development argument, so the story is just.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, never deny a poor nation its fair development, and work with care. Your credibility rests on the real carbon, the real flaws, and the real, financed alternative — a better path, not mere refusal; and care for those involved matters in a constrained space. State the carbon and the flaws precisely, offer the finance honestly, and press within the system and the world. An effort that is precise, fair, and offers a real alternative is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches or merely refuses, and far more just.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — and here, distinctively, the story is a global one: the largest tropical peatland on earth, a carbon store of planetary importance, threatened by oil, and a poor nation ready to protect it if the world helps pay. The story — the carbon bomb in the swamp forest, and the fair bargain to keep it — commands the world's attention.

Why Media Matters

The state, the oil interests, the funders, and the world behave differently when the global stakes and the fair bargain are visible. Media does three things here: it **connects the local forest communities to the global movement**, it **raises the stakes** for a state that seeks Congo Basin standing and for companies mindful of reputation, and it **brings the world's climate concern and finance** to a global carbon store. Because the peatland is of global importance, the international climate and environmental media are a genuine and powerful lever. But the Republic of Congo is a constrained state, so the media effort runs largely through **international climate and environmental media, the global movement, and careful factual documentation**, rather than confrontational domestic press — and with care for those involved.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the global carbon and the fair bargain. The strongest frame is at once dramatic and just: *beneath the swamp forests of the Congo lies the largest tropical peatland on earth, holding as much carbon as years of the world's emissions — and it is threatened by oil, in a poor nation that would protect it if the world helped pay to keep the carbon in the ground*. Put the global carbon and the fair bargain first, because the carbon commands the world and the bargain makes the case just. Keep it scrupulously accurate; the science is strong, and overstatement or a failure to acknowledge the development need would weaken it. The Congolese story is powerful because it is both a global climate cause and a fair deal for a poor nation.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, and to the constraints. **International climate and environmental media** for the world and the funders; **finance and investor channels** for the oil companies and financiers; **careful factual documentation** for the record; and **community and forest-people voices** for the local stake and rights. Because the domestic space is constrained, the international and finance channels matter most — the largest tropical peatland on earth, threatened by oil, is the story's distinctive, global power.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, fair, and respectful of the development need — the aim is to keep the peatland whole by funding a better path, not to deny a poor nation its future or to endanger those involved. Frame the story around the global carbon and the fair bargain, and be mindful of the constraints on dissent. Handle the state, the oil companies, the sovereignty argument, and the transboundary dimension with the neighbouring country factually and evenhandedly, honouring the fair development case. And sustain the story through the ongoing science and the finance conversation. Above all, let the real global stakes and the fair bargain carry the story, because that is where a Congolese effort is strongest and most just.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real project, the real carbon, and the real finance, keep it factual, offer a better path, and work with care. Here the global value, and the fair bargain, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for information — [project] and the Cuvette Centrale peatlands

To [ministry / authority],

I am writing on behalf of [community / organisation] regarding [project] and its effects on the peatlands and forest. To understand and respond, we respectfully request the **licences and project documents**, the **environmental assessment**, and the **carbon and peatland studies** for the affected area. We wish to help protect a globally vital peatland in keeping with the state's own commitments.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, organisation, contact]

8B: Invoking the State's Commitments

Subject: [Project], the peatlands, and the state's own pledges

To the [environment ministry / authority],

[Project] threatens the Cuvette Centrale peatlands — one of earth's greatest carbon stores — which the Republic of Congo has pledged to protect and on which it seeks to lead the Congo Basin. We respectfully urge that these pledges be honoured, that a proper modern assessment be conducted, and that protection funded by climate finance be pursued in place of drilling. We attach the carbon science and the record.

Respectfully,

[Name, organisation, contact]

8C: Proposing the Climate-Finance Alternative

Subject: Paying to keep the carbon in the ground at [location]

To [ministry / climate fund / partner],

We recognise the Republic of Congo's genuine need for revenue and its fair right to develop. We respectfully propose that, in place of drilling the peatlands, the nation be paid to keep this globally vital carbon in the ground — through [results-based payments / carbon and conservation finance / forest funds] — meeting the development need without the risk and the loss. We can help develop the proposal.

Respectfully,

[Name, organisation, contact]

8D: Letter to an Oil Company or Financier

Subject: The risks of peatland oil at [location]

To [company / financier],

We write regarding [block / project] in the Cuvette Centrale peatlands — a globally vital carbon store, on an assessment that predates the peatlands' discovery, with doubtful reserves. Proceeding would breach climate commitments and carry grave reputational and financial risk. We respectfully urge you to stay out of the peatlands, and we provide the science and the analysis.

Respectfully,

[Name, organisation, contact]

8E: Letter to a Climate Fund

Subject: A globally significant carbon store to protect at [location]

Dear [climate fund / partner],

The Cuvette Centrale holds one of earth's largest stores of carbon, now threatened by oil, in a poor nation willing to protect it if its development need is met. We respectfully request your support for **finance to keep this carbon in the ground** — a globally significant, fundable win. We can provide the carbon science, the finance model, and the local partnerships.

Respectfully,

[Name, organisation, contact]

8F: Letter on Community and Indigenous Rights

Subject: The rights of the forest communities of [location]

To [authority / partner / human-rights body],

The forest and Indigenous communities of [location] depend on the peatlands and forest that [project] threatens, and their rights and consent must be respected. We respectfully request that their land rights, their consent, and their benefit be honoured, and that they be included in any decision on the peatlands they call home. We attach their account.

Respectfully,

[Name, organisation, contact]

8G: Media / Documentation Pitch

Subject: The carbon bomb beneath the Congo swamp forest

Dear [journalist / editor],

Beneath the swamp forests of the Congo lies the largest tropical peatland on earth, holding as much carbon as years of the world's emissions — and it is threatened by oil, in a poor nation that would protect it if the world helped pay. There is a global climate story here, and a fair bargain, and we can provide the science, the community's voices, and an account that honours both the stakes and the development need.

Sincerely,

[Name, organisation, contact]

8H: Rallying the Local and Global Community

Subject: Our forest, the world's carbon — let us keep it whole together

Dear friends and allies,

The peatlands that are our home and the world's carbon store are threatened by oil. Together — forest communities and the world's climate movement — by documenting the carbon, invoking the state's own pledges, offering the finance to keep the carbon in the ground, and pressing the oil companies to stay out, we can keep the peatlands whole and fund a better path, without denying our nation its future. Please join us: share what you know, and add your voice.

With respect,

[Name, organisation]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a threat is acute — a new block awarded, drilling about to begin, a concession granted, an assessment waived — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and safest here, which means the global-value case, the state's commitments, and the international movement.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials — through the global stakes: **what carbon is threatened, and what the state pledged**. Identify the immediate pressure point — a **new block, imminent drilling, a concession, a waived assessment** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **international climate NGOs, the scientists, and the climate funders** at once, because for a global carbon store the world's movement and finance are the fastest routes to real, and safer, leverage — and begin at once to frame the **finance alternative**, because refusal without it ignores the fair need.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The global-value case** can be made at once, engaging the world's climate concern. **The state's commitments** can be invoked immediately. **The oil-company and financier pressure** can be brought quickly through the international movement. **The flawed assessment** can be

challenged at once. These outpace the slower work of delivering climate finance at scale — which must follow — because the global concern and the company pressure can be mobilised immediately. Above all, raise the global carbon stakes and the state's own pledges fast, because those command the world's attention.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can reach the global movement fast. Reach immediately to the **international climate and forest NGOs, the peatland scientists, the climate funders, and the sympathetic financiers**. A coalition raising the global carbon stakes, invoking the state's pledges, and pressing the oil interests is the most a rapid Congolese effort can do — and the world's climate movement can move fast. Speed favours the prepared: know the carbon, the pledges, and the finance model before the crisis breaks, and work through the global stakes with care.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the system is tilted by a poor, oil-dependent state with a genuine and fair need for revenue, by a constrained political space, and by the deep global injustice that a poor nation is asked to forgo its resources for a global good the rich have not paid for. This is the Republic of Congo's central, honest truth, and the whole guide has been shaped by it. Name it plainly, because pretending the development need is not real, or that the sovereignty argument is not fair, or that opposition is free, would be false.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **The state is poor and oil-dependent** — it needs the revenue and leans on oil. **The development argument is fair** — the nation has the same right to its resources that the rich nations used. **The space is constrained** — open dissent and independent civil society are limited. **And the injustice is global** — a poor nation is asked to keep the carbon in the ground for a world that has not yet paid. This is a tilt of poverty, fair need, and global inequity, and an effort here works it through the global value, the state's commitments, and above all the finance that meets the fair need, not through mere refusal or open confrontation.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted, use the levers that meet the fair need and engage the world. Lean on the **global climate value**, which brings the world's concern; the **state's own commitments**, holding it to its word; the **climate finance**, which answers the development need; the **flawed assessment and weak economics**, which undercut the oil; and the **oil-interest pressure and international movement**. Meet the sovereignty argument not with dismissal but with the honest offer that the world should pay to keep the carbon stored, so that protection is the nation's better deal. And press the rich world to deliver the finance, because the justice of the case is that those who caused the climate crisis should pay to keep a poor nation's carbon in the ground. A field tilted by poverty and global inequity is worked by meeting the need and engaging the world, not by denying a poor nation its future.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may achieve little visible change — the block may hold, the drilling may proceed, the finance may not come — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the need is real and the space constrained. But here the work is rarely wholly wasted: the **global carbon was documented, the state's pledges were invoked, the assessment was challenged, the oil interests were pressed, and the finance alternative was placed**

on the table — and every block delayed, every pledge invoked, every financier deterred, every step toward finance protects the carbon that remains. Press for the better path; even if a project proceeds, the global case you built and the finance model you advanced will shape the next decision, because a peatland the whole world needs will not be forgotten, and the world's willingness to pay for it grows.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In the Republic of Congo, alongside the fair development need, there is a real and documented concern of opacity in the oil and forest sectors: concessions granted without transparency, blocks whose ownership and terms are unclear, and revenues that too often enrich the few rather than the nation. This must be approached with care in a constrained state, and the safer, more effective route runs through the international transparency movement, the climate finance, and the global stakes.

Telling Capture from the Fair Need

In many resource states there is a line between a fair development need and the capture of resources by the few. The marks are specific: **concessions and blocks granted without transparency, unclear ownership and terms, revenues enriching elites rather than the nation, and assessments and process bypassed for private gain**. Be rigorous and careful: **distinguish the fair, honest development need from provable, documented opacity or capture**, and rely on the global stakes, the state's commitments, and the international transparency movement, because in a constrained space these are safer and more credible than accusation. And note the crucial point: where oil revenues enrich the few rather than the nation, the development argument for drilling the peatlands is itself undermined, for the poor gain little.

Responding to Capture — Through the System and the World, Carefully

Where opacity or capture is real, the response runs through the global levers and the transparency movement. Use the **international transparency movement and the extractives-transparency standards** to press for disclosure of the blocks, the ownership, and the terms. Use the **global climate value** to bring the world's scrutiny to a global carbon store. Use the **climate finance** to offer a transparent, nation-benefiting alternative to opaque oil deals. And use the **international partners and financiers** to insist on transparency and do-no-harm. Document carefully and protect those involved, because in a constrained space the record must be rigorous and the people shielded. Route the effort through the global stakes, the transparency movement, and the finance — not through open confrontation.

A Note on Safety and Care

This note matters throughout. The Republic of Congo is a constrained state with real limits on dissent and criticism of the government, so this work must be done with care, largely through international and within-system channels. Favour the **international climate, forest, and transparency movements, the finance channels, and careful documentation** over open confrontation; protect individuals, especially the forest and Indigenous communities and any local advocates whose position could be jeopardised; frame the work around the global stakes, the state's own commitments, and the fair finance bargain, not around challenging authority; and handle the government, the politics, the sovereignty argument, and the transboundary dimension factually and evenhandedly. Care here is not timidity; it is the recognition that the effective and safe path in the Republic of Congo runs through the global value, the state's commitments, and the finance, and that pressing too openly can cost vulnerable people dearly while achieving less than patient work through the world and the system.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others — all through the global stakes and the state's commitments. Here is how they fit into a single, careful Congolese effort.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the carbon-and-flaws file. **Target identification** aims it at the levers. **Local opposition**, understood as the local-and-global community, organises the forest people and the world's movement. **Legal, regulatory, and climate-governance** work presses the state's commitments, the finance, and the flawed assessment. **Media**, largely international, carries the global cause. The carbon-and-finance feeds all five at once — the global carbon is a value case, a commitment lever, a finance opportunity, and a world story together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, spanning the swamp forest and the world, they compound into the defence of a global treasure and a fair bargain for a poor nation.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the carbon and the flawed assessment; identify the state's commitments, the finance, and the oil interests; build the local-and-global coalition and begin documentation. **Middle (months 2–24):** invoke the state's pledges and challenge the assessment; advance the climate finance and the fair alternative; press the oil companies and financiers; and engage the world's movement. **Later (months and years):** deliver the finance to keep the carbon stored, secure the community's rights, and defend the peatlands against each new threat. A Congolese effort spans the local and the global, and its fruits — documentation, delay, finance, protection — are gradual; pace it accordingly, and let care and the fair bargain govern every step.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the carbon and the flaws; engage the world's climate concern; invoke the state's own pledges; offer the finance to keep the carbon stored; press the oil interests; and fund a better path.** The community and coalition that press all five, joining the local forest people to the world's movement, and funding the fair need, are the ones that can genuinely keep the peatlands whole — the kind of victory a poor, oil-dependent, but globally-watched state allows.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Keeping the Congo peatlands whole is genuinely difficult, and bound up with the poverty of an oil-dependent nation, the fairness of its right to develop, the constraint of its political space, and the deep injustice that a poor country is asked to forgo its resources for a global good, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: the nation is poor and oil-dependent, its development argument is fair, the space is constrained, and no threat is beaten. And yet the effort is far from futile, because the peatlands are of global climate value that brings the world's concern and finance to bear, the state has signed commitments to protect them and seeks Congo Basin standing, the world could pay to keep the carbon in the ground, and the oil beneath is of doubtful worth — and those levers of the global value, the state's commitments, the climate finance, and the oil-interest pressure are real.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The carbon makes it a global cause — the world has reason, and means, to help keep the peatland whole. The state made pledges it can be held to. The finance can meet the fair need — paying to keep the carbon stored answers the sovereignty argument. But the nation is poor, the need real, the argument fair, and the space constrained.** Hold both truths at once: real, global levers grounded in the peatland's worth and the state's word, and the honest weight of a poor nation's fair need.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the fairness — that give these efforts their force. Document the carbon and the flaws. Engage the world's climate concern. Invoke the state's own pledges. Offer the finance to keep the carbon stored. Press the oil interests. And fund a better path — because for a peatland the whole world needs, held by a poor nation with a fair claim to develop, an effort that keeps it whole by paying for a better path, through the global stakes and the state's own word, is the one that is both effective and just.

Beneath the swamp forests of the northern Congo lies the largest tropical peatland on earth, a store of carbon as vast as years of the whole world's emissions, sheltering gorillas and forest elephants and rare life, and sustaining the fishing and forest communities who have always lived there; and it is threatened by the drilling for oil beneath it, licensed on an assessment so old it predated the peatland's own discovery, in a poor and oil-dependent nation that fairly claims the same right to its resources that the rich world used to build its wealth. This guide has hidden none of that, nor pretended that the development need is not real, or that the sovereignty argument is not fair, or that a constrained state's political space is open, and there is no final victory here to promise you. But the very thing that makes this peatland's fate so grave is also the lever: because it holds carbon the whole planet needs kept in the ground, the whole planet has both the reason and the means to help — not by denying a poor nation its future, but by paying for a better one, so that keeping the carbon stored becomes the nation's better deal and the world's shared gain. There is no easy victory, and no escaping the fair claim of a poor nation to develop; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted on care for those who act and justice for those who need. But the peatlands and forests of the Congo are worth keeping whole, the levers that run through their global worth and the world's willingness to pay are real, and the patient, careful work of documenting the carbon, invoking the state's own word, and funding a better path is one that communities and their allies can genuinely do — from the swamp forest to the world — and keep a treasure of the whole earth intact. So can you.